

MORPHOLOGY & SPELLING

High School Foundations | Unit 10

Unlock Academic Vocabulary



Today I am learning to use word parts and context to unlock academic vocabulary.

1 Learn the Meaning

Academic words often contain meaningful prefixes, bases or roots, and suffixes. Start by finding a familiar word part, combine the clues from each part, then check whether the sentence context confirms your meaning. Morphology gives a strong starting point - context refines it.

interdependent

inter- + depend + -ent

counterproductive

counter- + product + -ive

semipermeable

semi- + permeable

multicultural

multi- + culture + -al

2 Build the Word

Use the base or related word and the affixes shown to build each academic word. Then add a short meaning clue.

Base / related	Add affixes	New word	Meaning clue
depend	inter- + -ent		
product	counter- + -ive		
culture	multi- + -al		
permeable	semi-		
agree	dis- + -ment		

3 Read and Notice

During an environmental studies project, students examined how communities respond to changing conditions. They read a multinational report explaining that transport, housing and water systems are interdependent: a change in one system can affect the others. The report warned that a counterproductive decision may solve one problem while creating another, so planners must consider consequences across the whole system.

In science, the class investigated semipermeable membranes and compared them with impermeable materials. They discussed how multicellular organisms depend on specialised cells working together and how reusable materials can reduce waste. When an unfamiliar term appeared, students first looked for a prefix, base or root, and suffix before using the surrounding sentence to refine the meaning.

The same strategy helped in history and geography. Words such as international, multicultural, reorganisation and disagreement became easier to interpret when students connected them with familiar word families. Even when a root was less obvious, a known affix often supplied a useful clue.

By the end of the lesson, the students understood that morphology does not replace context. Instead, word parts provide an evidence-based first hypothesis about meaning, and the sentence or paragraph helps confirm, adjust or reject that hypothesis.



Highlight academic words with useful affixes. Underline a base or root clue, then use the sentence to check your inferred meaning.

4 Word Detective

Choose one academic word from the passage and use morphology plus context to investigate its meaning.

- Write an academic word from the passage.

- What base, root or related word can you identify?

- Which prefix and suffixes give you meaning clues?

- What meaning do you infer, and how does the context confirm it?

5 Sort the Words

Sort the words by which word part gives the strongest first meaning clue.

multicultural

interdependent

counterargument

semipermeable

planetary

dangerous

creative

activation

Prefix gives main clue

Suffix / family gives clue

6 Use It in Writing

Complete the sentence starters.

- The word interdependent probably means

- Choose one academic word. Show its parts, then use it accurately in a sentence.



Parent check

Tick the skills your learner has demonstrated.

- ☐ Breaks an academic word into meaningful parts
- ☐ Identifies a base or root and useful affixes
- ☐ Uses morphology and context together to infer meaning
- ☐ Reads and uses academic vocabulary accurately in context



Capture idea:

Find an unfamiliar word in a science, history or information text. Record it, split it into useful parts, infer a meaning, then check the context.